# Why a Never-Punt Offense Won in Arkansas and Struggled in South Carolina

### Evidence from Pulaski Academy (2019-2020) and Presbyterian College (2021), with an Overtime SZN media archive

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October 31, 2026

## Abstract

Kevin Kelley coached Pulaski Academy to nine Arkansas state titles (216-29-1 from 2003 to 2020) with an offense known for almost never punting. In 2021 he took the same approach to Presbyterian College, an FCS program, and the team went 2-9. This paper asks whether the never-punt philosophy explains the difference. Using audited game, season and fourth-down data, it finds that Presbyterian outgained its opponents by 865 yards (5,697 to 4,832) yet was outscored 590 to 404, because opponents scored 12.2 points per 100 yards against Presbyterian's 7.1. Presbyterian converted 29 of 84 fourth-down attempts (34.5%), committed 46 turnovers and played the season with a young roster, while the one available Pulaski figure (2020: 31 of 66, 47.0%) is higher. None of the fourth-down comparisons is statistically significant, no play-by-play data exist to test the decisions themselves, and Pulaski's 2019 fourth-down, turnover and defensive data remain missing. The evidence supports a narrower conclusion than the losing record suggests: the strategy was one contributor among several, and its size cannot be measured with the data collected. A companion archive separates confirmed from merely possible appearances in Overtime SZN's *To The House* series, which is better used as a source of video for future play-level coding than as evidence in itself.

## 1. Introduction

Kelley's reputation rests on three habits: going for it on fourth down instead of punting, attempting nearly every kickoff as an onside kick, and trying two-point conversions after touchdowns. At Pulaski Academy, a private school in Little Rock, the approach coincided with sustained dominance. Hired by Presbyterian on May 6, 2021, Kelley took over a program that had gone 16-46 since the start of the 2015 season. His first game, an 84-43 win over NAIA St. Andrews, set FCS passing records. The rest of the season was far harder.

A losing record alone does not show that a strategy failed. A team can lose because of its decisions, its execution, its turnovers, its defense, the quality of its opponents, or some mixture. This paper therefore separates those explanations as far as the data allow and is explicit about what they cannot establish. Two questions guide it:

- Q1. What distinguishes Presbyterian's 2021 results from Pulaski Academy's, and which candidate explanations does the evidence support?

- Q2. What can Overtime SZN's documentaries on both programs tell us, and how reliably?

# 2. Hypotheses

Five candidate explanations for the 2021 season are examined, each stated so that evidence could count against it.

- H1 (execution). Presbyterian converted fourth downs at a lower rate than its opponents and than Pulaski.
- H2 (turnovers). Turnovers, including those that gave opponents short fields, explain the points gap.
- H3 (efficiency and defense). The gap lies in how many points each side scored per yard, not in how many yards it gained.
- H4 (context). A young roster at a higher level of competition, in a league without athletic scholarships, made the same approach harder to run.
- H5 (the rule itself). Never punting, as a decision rule, cost Presbyterian wins relative to a punting alternative.

# 3. Data

## 3.1 Sources

Game results, season totals and fourth-down tables for Presbyterian come from the school's published statistics, cross-checked against Wikipedia box scores, CBS/AP game coverage, a Presbyterian press release, and season reports from Action Network and the Post and Courier. Pulaski results come from MaxPreps and Fearless Friday (2019 scores, which agree) and Arkansas Democrat-Gazette coverage. Kelley's career record comes from Sports Illustrated and the Sheridan School District. The Overtime SZN archive draws on press releases, Democrat-Gazette reporting, a student-newspaper opinion piece and YouTube pages. Every source is listed in the project workbook.

## 3.2 Audit

The starting workbook was audited before any analysis, and the audit changed the data. Table 1 summarizes the material findings; all 24 checks are in the workbook's Audit Log.

*Table 1. Material audit findings.*

| Finding | Effect |
|---|---|
| The sheet labeled Presbyterian's game-by-game offense held the opponents' offense (rush yards and rush touchdowns matched Presbyterian's season totals allowed exactly) | Relabeled; replaced with Presbyterian's own figures for 6 of 11 games, 5 marked MISSING |
| St. Andrews was dated September 22 | Corrected to September 4 (season opener) |
| Presbyterian punts: 14 in the season sheet, 13 in one recap, 4 in game rows | Unresolved; range 13-14 used, game-row column treated as incomplete |
| Fourth-down team/opponent orientation was in doubt | Resolved: 17-for-50 through game 7 matches a contemporaneous report |

| Finding | Effect |
|---|---|
| Pulaski 2019 fourth-down, punt, turnover and defensive data absent | Still missing; Pulaski 2020 fourth-down data (31 of 66) added from one article |
| Futa Shinakawa / Joseph Rhimon spellings | Probable misspellings of Futa Shinkawa and Joseph Himon II; flagged, not merged |

Missing values are marked MISSING throughout. None is estimated.

### 3.3 Samples

Presbyterian contributes 11 games and Pulaski 14 (2019) plus a partial 2020 season. These are small samples from different competitive levels: Arkansas Class 5A high school football and a Pioneer Football League FCS program. Every statistical result below should be read as descriptive.

## 4. Methods

### 4.1 Interval and test for rates

Fourth-down conversion rates carry 95% Wilson intervals. Two-group comparisons use Fisher's exact test, which suits small counts.

### 4.2 Game-level association

For Presbyterian's 11 games, point margin is correlated with fourth-down attempts and with conversion rate. Significance comes from a permutation test (20,000 shuffles). A leave-one-out check shows how much one game moves the result, and the correlation is recomputed without the two non-FCS wins.

### 4.3 Efficiency accounting

Let Y be yards and P points, with subscripts F (for Presbyterian) and A (against). The combined average efficiency is e = (P_F + P_A) / (Y_F + Y_A). The point differential then splits exactly into three parts: the yardage edge, (Y_F - Y_A) × e; the offense's shortfall, P_F - Y_F × e; and the opponents' excess, Y_A × e - P_A. This locates where a yardage edge went but says nothing about why.

### 4.4 Break-even sensitivity

Going for it beats punting when p × G - (1 - p) × C > 0, where p is the conversion probability, G the gain from converting relative to punting, and C the loss from failing relative to punting. The break-even rate is p* = C / (G + C) = r / (1 + r), with r = C / G. Estimating r by field position and distance requires play-by-play data, so the model is used as a sensitivity analysis: for an observed conversion rate p, going for it is worthwhile only where r is no greater than p / (1 - p). A first version of this analysis used an assumed expected-points curve; it implied that even Pulaski's 47% rate was unprofitable in most situations, which exposed the curve as poorly calibrated, so it was dropped rather than reported.

### 4.5 Pythagorean expectation

Expected win percentage is P_F^k / (P_F^k + P_A^k) with the conventional football exponent k = 2.37. It indicates whether a record was luckier or unluckier than its scoring margin implied.

# 5. Results

## 5.1 Presbyterian outgained opponents and lost by 186 points

Presbyterian totaled 5,697 yards (517.9 per game) against 4,832 allowed, an edge of 865 yards, and was outscored 590 to 404. Points per 100 yards were 7.1 for Presbyterian and 12.2 for opponents. At the combined average of 9.4, the yardage edge was worth +82 points, the offense scored 134 below average, and opponents scored 134 above average, summing to -186 (Figure 1). Opponents scored 50 rushing touchdowns, 4.5 per game.

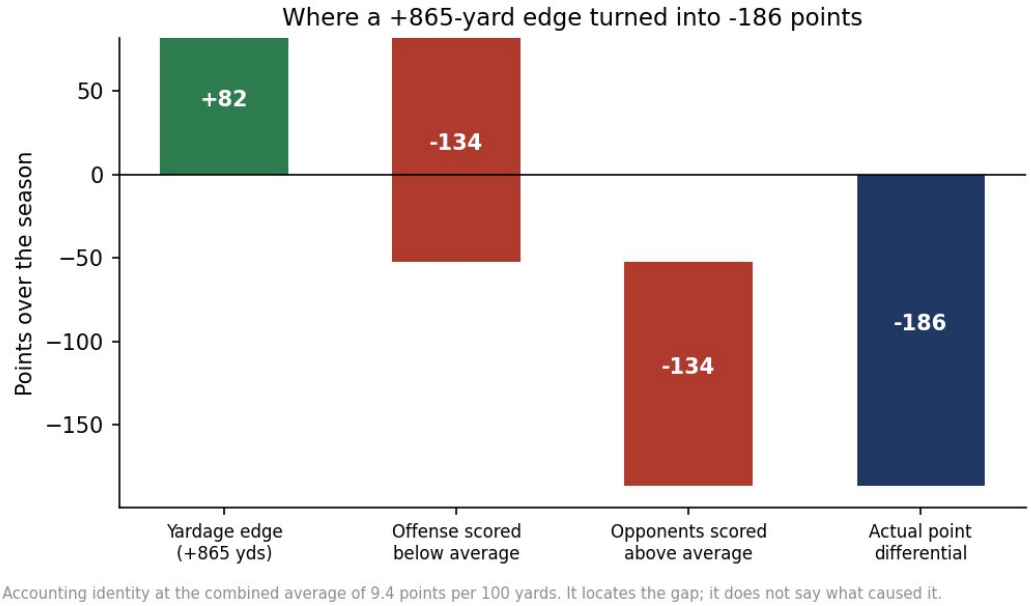



***Figure 1.*** *Decomposition of Presbyterian's -186 point differential at the combined average efficiency.*

## 5.2 Fourth-down execution (H1)

*Table 2. Fourth-down conversion.*

| Group | Conversions | Attempts | Rate | 95% interval | Attempts per game |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Presbyterian 2021 | 29 | 84 | 34.5% | 25.2% to 45.2% | 7.6 |
| Presbyterian's opponents | 18 | 38 | 47.4% | 32.5% to 62.7% | 3.5 |
| Pulaski 2020 | 31 | 66 | 47.0% | 35.4% to 58.8% | 5.1 |

Presbyterian's rate trails both comparison groups, but the intervals overlap. Fisher's exact test gives p = 0.23 against its opponents and p = 0.13 against Pulaski 2020 (Figure 2). Presbyterian converted 17 of 50 through game 7 (34.0%) and 12 of 34 afterward (35.3%), so the rate did not move when the team's approach reportedly changed. H1 is supported descriptively and not statistically.

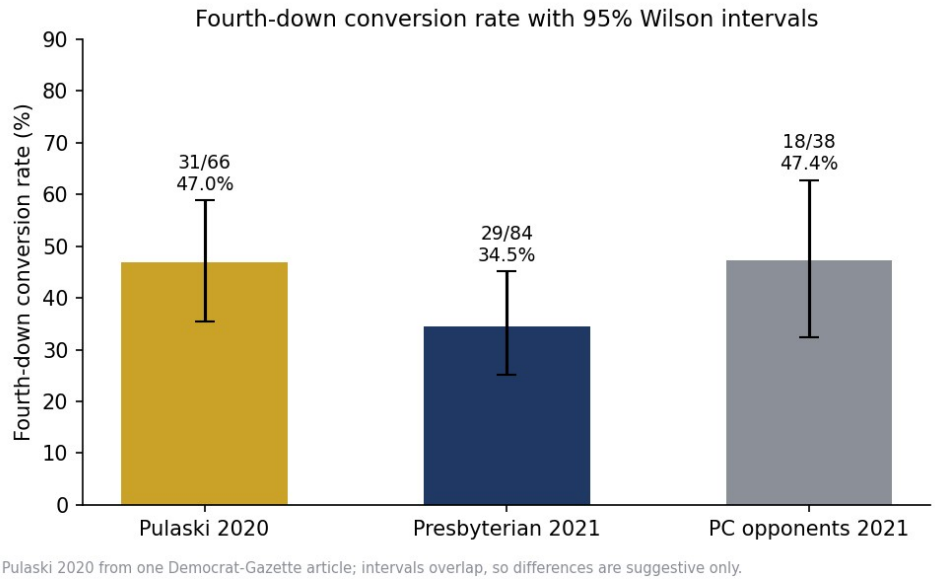



***Figure 2.*** *Fourth-down conversion rates with 95% Wilson intervals. Pulaski 2020 comes from a single Democrat-Gazette article.*

## 5.3 Turnovers (H2)

Presbyterian threw 34 interceptions and lost 12 fumbles, 46 turnovers or 4.2 per game, including seven interceptions in the 72-0 loss at Campbell. Opponent turnovers and starting field position are not in the dataset, so the effect of these turnovers on the points gap cannot be quantified. H2 is consistent with the data and untested.

## 5.4 Efficiency, defense and field position (H3)

The 12.2 versus 7.1 points per 100 yards is the central quantitative result. Presbyterian's yardage was strong. What failed was converting yardage into points on offense and preventing it on defense. Contemporary reporting adds context that points the same way: heavy onside-kick use (31 attempts and 6 recoveries through seven games), no field goals attempted, and 54 or more points allowed in eight losses. The workbook cannot separate defense from the field position the offense surrendered.

## 5.5 Game-level association

Across 11 games, margin correlates -0.50 with fourth-down attempts (permutation $p = 0.12$) and +0.42 with conversion rate ($p = 0.19$). Leaving out one game at a time moves the first correlation between -0.70 and -0.23. Removing the two wins over non-FCS opponents turns it to +0.30 ($p = 0.44$). Because Presbyterian went for it nearly every time, games in which it trailed produced more possessions and more fourth downs, so these correlations mostly reflect game state (Figure 3).

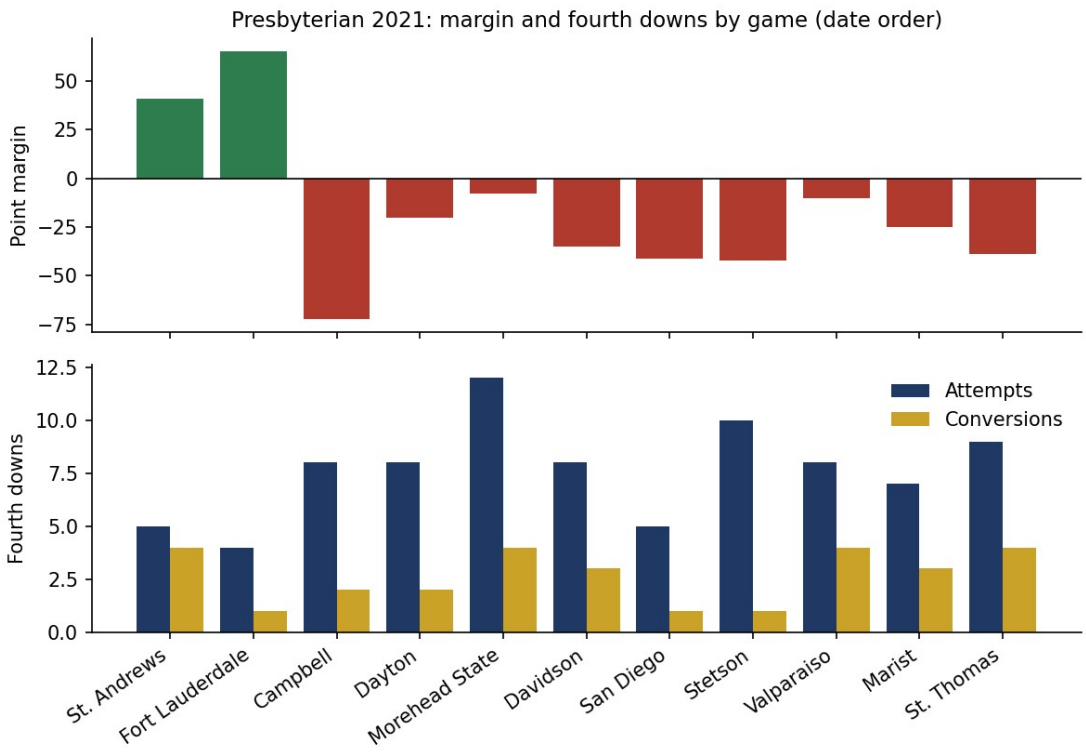



***Figure 3.*** *Presbyterian 2021 point margin by game, in date order, with fourth-down attempts and conversions.*

## 5.6 Pulaski Academy (H4 context)

In 2019 Pulaski went 12-2 and scored 56.4 points per game while allowing 30.6, a margin of +25.8; Presbyterian's was -16.9. Pulaski's defense also gave up many points, so its success depended on offensive scoring and on possessions won through onside kicks and fourth-down conversions. Pythagorean expectation puts Pulaski 2019 at 11.3 wins (actual 12) and Presbyterian 2021 at 3.2 (actual 2), so neither record was far from its scoring margin and Presbyterian was not simply unlucky. Pulaski reportedly has not punted since 2014, while Presbyterian punted 13 to 14 times, most of them after the first seven games.

The contexts differ sharply. Arkansas Class 5A and the FCS differ in talent gaps, a first-year Presbyterian roster was reported to include 82 freshmen, and the Pioneer Football League does not offer athletic scholarships. Presbyterian went 0-9 against all opponents other than St. Andrews and Fort Lauderdale. One player spans both programs: wide receiver Jalyn Witcher played for Pulaski in 2020 and was a first-team All-PFL selection at Presbyterian in 2021. H4 is plausible and unmeasured.

## 5.7 What the observed rates require (H5)

Using the break-even relation, Presbyterian's 34.5% rate justifies going for it only where a failed attempt costs no more than 0.53 times what a conversion gains. Pulaski's 47.0% justifies it up to a ratio of 0.89, and the opponents' 47.4% up to 0.90 (Figure 4). Where in the field those attempts occurred, and how far they had to go, is unknown. A midseason report cited a fourth-and-8 from the Presbyterian 12 while trailing, a case that is hard to defend on expected-points grounds, but one example is not a rate. H5 cannot be tested with the data collected.

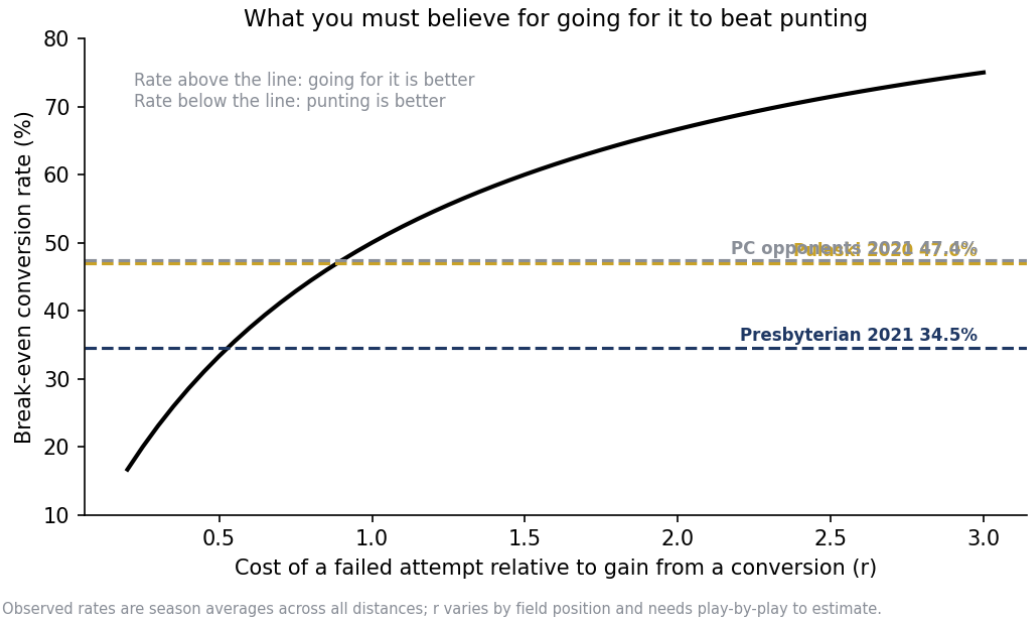



***Figure 4.*** *Break-even conversion rate as a function of the cost-to-gain ratio r, with each group's observed rate.*

# 6. Overtime SZN archive (Q2)

The archive records what is documented and keeps confirmed appearances separate from possible matches.

*Table 3. Overtime SZN archive status.*

| Title or person | Status | Basis |
|---|---|---|
| To The House, season 1 (Pulaski 2019) | Confirmed, 15 episodes | Democrat-Gazette; premiere date disputed (December 2019 release vs. about May 9, 2020 report) |
| To The House, Presbyterian season | Confirmed, 12 parts | One secondary source (student opinion piece); not checked on YouTube |
| To The House, season 2 | Unverified | Appears in a YouTube description; contents unknown |
| Kevin Kelley | Confirmed | Subject of both series |
| Steve Raum | Confirmed | Overtime producer, named in a photo caption |
| Braden Bratcher, Harrison Lane | Filmed; on-screen appearance unconfirmed | Democrat-Gazette caption |
| Joe Himon (Joseph Himon II), Futa Shinkawa, Jalyn Witcher | Possible match | Documented players; no source ties them to an episode |
| Jayden Kelley, Savannah Goodwin | No match found | Searches returned nothing relevant |

The one reviewer account of the Presbyterian series describes locker-room friction, the absence of scholarships and Kelley eventually punting. It is an opinion piece, not an analysis of the episodes. More generally, documentaries are edited for narrative, so they cannot substitute for play-level data. Their

best use here is as a source of video: coding each fourth down in the episodes (down, distance, field position, score, outcome) would fill the empty Fourth-Down Decisions sheet and make H5 testable (Figure 5 shows the evidence map and pipeline).

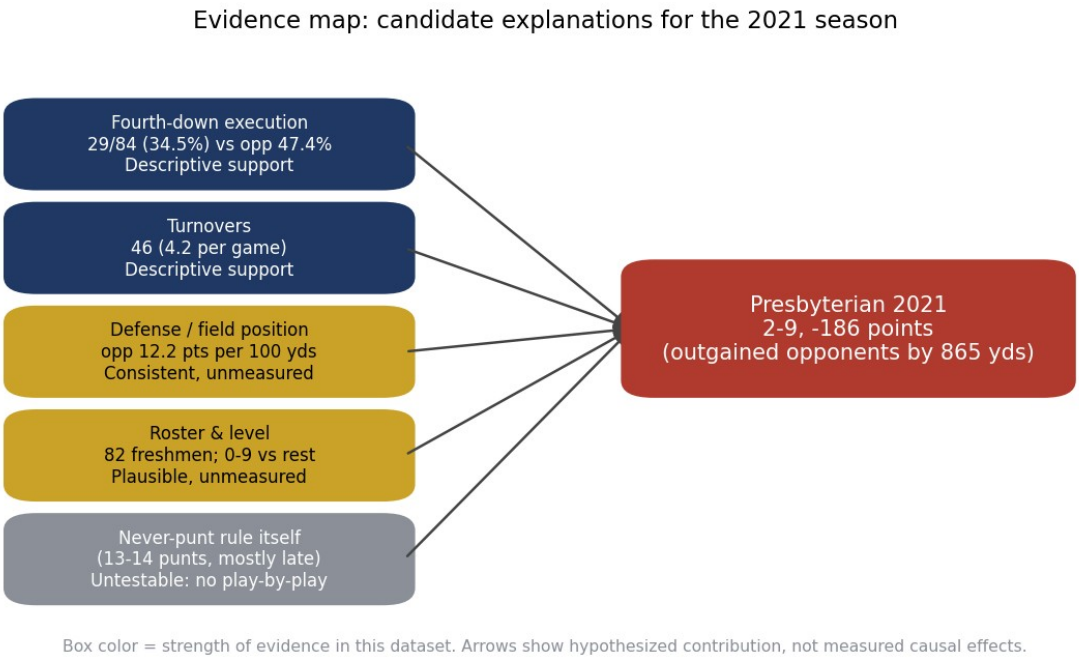
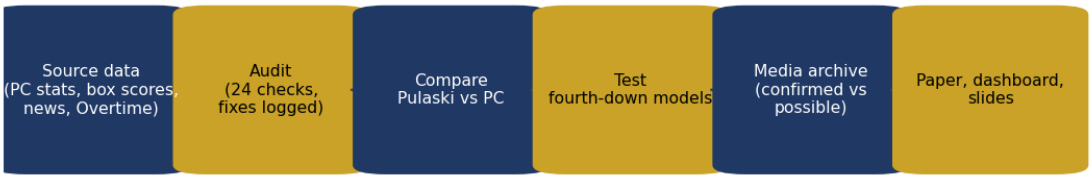



***Figure 5.*** *Evidence map of candidate explanations, and the research pipeline.*




# 7. Discussion

Three things stand out. First, Presbyterian's offense produced yards, so the problem was not an inability to move the ball. Second, the points gap is large and symmetrical: about 134 points from offense scoring below average and 134 from opponents scoring above it. Turnovers and short fields could plausibly drive both, since a turnover cuts an offense's scoring chances and extends the opponent's, but the data cannot confirm that. Third, the one Pulaski comparison available shows a higher conversion rate with fewer attempts per game, consistent with a team that faced weaker opponents and trailed less often. This is a hypothesis, not a finding.

The analysis supports a middle position between two common readings. Calling never-punt the cause of the losing season would confuse correlation with causation: no evidence here isolates the rule from roster, opponent and execution effects. Calling it blameless would overlook 55 failed attempts, a conversion rate well under the opponents', and a team that moved away from the rule late in the season.

## 8. Limitations

- Eleven Presbyterian games and one partial Pulaski season; no result is statistically significant.
- Pulaski's fourth-down figure comes from one article and covers 2020, not 2019. Pulaski turnovers, defense and field position are missing.
- No play-by-play, distance or field-position data exist, so decision quality cannot be assessed.
- The punt count is unresolved (4, 13 or 14).
- The two levels of competition differ, so cross-program comparisons are suggestive only.
- The Overtime SZN archive relies partly on secondary sources and on one opinion piece for the Presbyterian series.
- The Pythagorean exponent and the efficiency decomposition are conventions and accounting identities, not fitted causal models.

## 9. Conclusion

The data show a Presbyterian team that gained more yards than its opponents and lost by 186 points, converted fourth downs at a below-average rate, turned the ball over 46 times and could not stop opponents from scoring. They do not show that never punting caused the season. The honest conclusion is that the philosophy was one contributor among several, with an unmeasured size, and the next step with the most value is play-by-play fourth-down data, coded from game video, for both programs.

## 10. Reproducibility

The project folder contains the audited workbook (kevin_kelley_research_workbook_v2.xlsx), CSV exports of every sheet, analysis.py (all models and figures), model_results.json, seven figures, an interactive dashboard (dashboard.html), a slide deck (kelley_slides.pptx) and a README. Running analysis.py regenerates every number and figure from the CSV files. Missing data are marked and never imputed.

## Sources

Presbyterian athletics (2021 football statistics and releases); Wikipedia (2021 Presbyterian Blue Hose football team; Kevin Kelley); Action Network, "Coach Never-Punt" season recap (Dec. 2021); Post and Courier, midseason column (Oct. 2021); CBS Sports/AP, St. Andrews game (Sept. 2021); Arkansas Democrat-Gazette on Pulaski Academy (2020 and Oct. 12, 2021) and on To The House (May 16, 2020); Sports Illustrated (May 2021; Dec. 2023); Sheridan School District; MaxPreps and Fearless Friday (Pulaski 2019); The Bluestocking, opinion piece on Overtime's series (Aug. 2022); Gatorade and SI player pages (Joe Himon). Full links are in the workbook's Sources sheet.